

Liturgical Worship

prc-liturgical-worship

Worship Style · Liturgy · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

A formal liturgy or lectionary is not commanded but is a permissible Christian-liberty matter when it preserves the gospel and Scripture's primacy.

In plain language

This proposition says a set liturgy or lectionary is not required by Scripture but is allowed as a matter of Christian freedom, so long as the gospel and the Bible's authority stay central. The Bible words pull in more than one direction, so the verdict is disputed. In Romans 14, verses 5 and 6, the apostle handles one believer treating certain days as special and another treating all days alike. The key verb 'let each be fully convinced' (plerophoreo) means to be fully convinced in one's own 'mind' (nous), and the practice is done to the Lord with thanksgiving ('gives thanks', eucharisteo). That gives a clear freedom principle for disputed customs, but the passage is about days and food, not about how a congregation orders its service. First Corinthians 14, verse 40 commands that all things be done 'decently' (euschemonos) and 'according to order' (kata taxin). The Greek word for order, 'taxis', splits two ways across the Bible. It means plain tidiness here and in Colossians 2, verse 5, but elsewhere it means a fixed appointed arrangement, like the priestly course in Luke 1, verse 8, or the Melchizedek order in Hebrews. So the word warrants structure but cannot by itself prove a set liturgy is required. At the same time, the canon clearly carries set wording. The Aramaic cry 'our Lord, come' (maranatha, also written marana tha) is kept untranslated in First Corinthians 16, verse 22, and appears only once (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), which is the mark of a received fixed acclamation. The model prayer in Matthew 6, verse 9, is introduced with the adverb 'in this way' (houtos) meaning 'pray in this way', and that adverb itself is two-sided. It can mean follow this template or recite just like this, and the grammar here does not settle which sense applies. Acts 2, verse 42 names four recurring activities of the early gathering, 'the teaching' (didache), 'the fellowship' (koinonia), 'the breaking of the bread', and 'the prayers' (proseuche), each marked with the word 'the', but the verse describes what the believers actually did rather than commanding any specific script. So the lexicon supplies precedent for set forms and supplies a freedom principle for disputable practice, yet no text actually commands or forbids a fixed liturgy. Whether the freedom rule from days and food rightly extends to the form of corporate worship is an inference the words allow but do not settle. Different worship principles read the same data to opposite conclusions, which is why the lexical pattern is best described as contested rather than settled.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0281	ἀμήν	amēn	amen	
G1322	διδάχῃ	didache	teaching	30
G2156	εὐσχημόνως	euschemonos	properly	3

G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteo	to thank	38
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2842	κοινωνία	koinōnia	participation	
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	117
G3134	μαράνα θά	marana tha	Come, Lord!	1
G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	24
G3779	οὕτως	houtos	thus(-ly)	215
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4335	προσευχή	proseuche	prayer	36
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	86
G4342	προσκαρτερέω	proskartereo	to continue in/with	10
G5010	τάξις	taxis	order	10
G5426	φρονέω	phroneo	to reason	30
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The cited corpus co-attests fixed set forms and free participatory contribution within the same Pauline material and never ranks one above the other, so the proposition that a formal liturgy is uncommanded yet permissible is materially contested. Romans 14:5-6 places the observance of days under each conscience with the verb 'let each be fully convinced' (plerophoreo, G4135, in the present passive imperative form, meaning a command for an ongoing state) and the participle 'regarding' (phroneo, G5426, present active participle, meaning the ongoing act of regarding), oriented to the Lord with 'gives thanks' (eucharisteo, G2168), which yields a liberty principle (a freedom-of-conscience rule) for disputable matters but speaks to days and food and not to corporate worship form. 1 Corinthians 14:40 commands 'according to order' (kata taxin, G5010) and 'decently' (euschemonos, G2156), arrangement and decorum, but 'order' (taxis) carries two attested senses across the canon, plain orderliness in 1 Corinthians 14:40 and Colossians 2:5 against fixed appointed arrangement in Luke 1:8 and the Melchizedek order in Hebrews, so the noun alone cannot mandate a set liturgy. Set forms are present: the Aramaic acclamation 'our Lord, come' (marana tha, G3134, a hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, 1 Corinthians 16:22) preserved untranslated, the model prayer introduced by 'in this way' (houtos, G3779, Matthew 6:9), the four articular elements (each carrying the article 'the') of Acts 2:42 ('the teaching' te didache, 'the fellowship' te koinonia, 'the breaking of the bread' te klasei tou artou, 'the prayers' tais proseuchais), but none of these texts contains an imperative requiring a fixed liturgical script. Because the canon supplies BOTH set elements AND free contribution and the vocabulary does not rank them, the lexicon underdetermines the proposition's permissibility-as-liberty claim.

Scripture

Rom.14.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Reasoning. One person 'judges' (krinei, G2919, present active indicative, meaning an ongoing simple statement of fact) one day above another, another judges every day alike. The closing clause is 'let each be fully convinced in his own mind' (hekastos en to idio noi pleroforeistho, with plerophoreo G4135 in the present passive imperative third singular form, meaning an ongoing command directed at the subject, and 'mind' nous, G3563, in the dative singular, meaning a noun in the 'to/in/by-X' grammatical form). The grammar commits the matter of observing days to settled individual conviction rather than to a binding rule, establishing a liberty (freedom-of-conscience) frame for a disputable observance, but the referent is days and food, not corporate worship form.

Rom.14.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5426 φρονέω, G2168 εὐχαριστέω

Reasoning. The one who regards the day ('the one regarding the day' ho phronon ten hemeran, with phroneo G5426 as a present active participle, meaning the ongoing act of regarding) regards it 'to the Lord' (kurio), and the one who eats 'gives thanks to God' (eucharistei to theo, eucharisteo G2168). The repeated dative (the 'to/in/by-X' form) 'to the Lord' (kurio) and 'to God' (theo) subordinates either practice to God-ward intent, so divergent observance is licit when oriented to the Lord, which supports liberty (freedom of conscience) in disputable practice but does not name fixed corporate liturgy as the thing being permitted.

1Cor.14.40 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5010 τάξις, G2156 εὐσχημόνως

Reasoning. 'Let all things be done decently and according to order' (panta de euschemonos kai kata taxin ginestho, with euschemonos G2156 meaning decently and taxis G5010 meaning order). The imperative 'let be done' (ginestho) is the same form that governs 1 Corinthians 14:26, 'let all things be done for building up' (panta pros oikodomen), so one verb binds both the freedom and the order poles in the same chapter. 'Order' (taxis, G5010) is two-sensed across the canon: plain arrangement in 1 Corinthians 14:40 and Colossians 2:5 against a fixed appointed course in Luke 1:8 (the priestly division) and the Melchizedek order in Hebrews 5:6, 5:10, 6:20, 7:11, 7:17, 7:21. The verse supplies an ordering imperative but the noun by itself cannot mandate a specific liturgy.

1Cor.16.22 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3134 μαράνα θά

Reasoning. 'Our Lord, come' (marana tha, G3134) is an Aramaic transliteration preserved inside a Greek letter. The Strong code occurs exactly once in the canon (a hapax, meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), which is the very mark of a received liturgical acclamation imported from earlier worship usage rather than coined for the letter. The form evidences fixed set wording in the apostolic assemblies, which complicates any claim that only free unscripted utterance is apostolic, but the verse contains no imperative requiring its recitation.

Matt.6.9 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3779 οὕτως, G4336 προσεύχομαι

Reasoning. 'In this way then pray' (houtos oun proseuchesthe humeis, with houtos G3779 as an adverb meaning 'in this way' and proseuchomai G4336 in the present middle imperative second plural form, meaning an ongoing command addressed to a group). The adverb 'in this way' (houtos) has two attested ranges across its 215 canon occurrences: manner template (do it in this kind of way) and exact replication (in just this way), and the morphology here does not adjudicate between them, so the model prayer can be read as a free pattern or as a set recitation. The lexicon supplies warrant for patterned prayer without settling whether fixed recitation is commanded.

Acts.2.42 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4342 προσκατερέω, G1322 διδασκῶ, G2842 κοινωνία, G4335 προσευχή

Reasoning. 'And they were continually devoted to the teaching of the apostles and to the fellowship, to the breaking of the bread and to the prayers' (esan de proskarterountes te didache ton apostolon kai te koinonia, te klasei tou artou kai tais proseuchais). Four articular datives (nouns in the 'to/in/by-X' form, each carrying the article 'the'): 'the teaching' (didache, G1322), 'the fellowship' (koinonia, G2842), 'the breaking of the bread' (klasis tou artou, with G0740 for 'bread' artos), 'the prayers' (proseuche, G4335), governed by the periphrastic imperfect of 'devote oneself continually' (proskartereo, G4342, the imperfect being ongoing or repeated past action). The definite articles mark these as named recognized recurring elements of the gathering, which warrants regularly ordered elements as a descriptive apostolic pattern, but the verse is indicative description not imperative prescription, so it does not command any specific liturgical script beyond the four headings.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.14.6	Exod.12.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.14.40 · addressed

'According to order' (kata taxin) commands ordering of corporate worship but the noun 'order' (taxis) denotes arrangement, not a prescribed text, and across the canon it splits into plain orderliness (1 Corinthians 14:40, Colossians 2:5) against fixed appointed arrangement (Luke 1:8, Hebrews 5:6 etc.). The verse therefore commands order without commanding a particular liturgy and is consistent with the liberty (freedom-of-conscience) reading.

1Cor.16.22 · addressed

The preserved Aramaic 'our Lord, come' (marana tha) proves that fixed formulaic acclamation existed apostolically, which undercuts the claim that set forms are inherently illicit. But the verse does not contain an imperative requiring its recitation, so it shows the permissibility pole as historically attested without proving the proposition's liberty (freedom-of-conscience) framing, which remains defensible rather than demonstrated.

Matt.6.9 · unaddressed

The adverb 'in this way' (houtos) is lexically two-sensed (template manner versus exact replication) and the morphology of 'pray' (proseuchesthe, present plural imperative, meaning an ongoing command to a group) does not disambiguate. The bundle supplies no grammatical feature ranking the senses, so whether the model prayer commands a fixed recitation or a free pattern cannot be resolved from the lexicon alone. This is the central lexical underdetermination (the words alone cannot settle the question) behind the disputed verdict.

Acts.2.42 · addressed

The four articular elements (each carrying the article 'the') warrant recurring named elements of the gathering, the closest the canon comes to a normative description of corporate practice, but the verse is indicative narrative description of what the assembly actually did, not an imperative binding every assembly to a fixed script. It strengthens the case for ordered named elements without commanding any specific liturgical text.

Concordance traversed

G4135, G5426, G2919, G2168, G3563, G2250, G5010, G2156, G3779, G4336, G3134, G5568, G4342, G1322, G4335, G0281

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units (places where Greek manuscripts differ) in the bundle for the cited verses bear on the order versus freedom question. The readings at Romans 14:5-6, 1 Corinthians 14:40, 1 Corinthians 16:22, Matthew 6:9, and Acts 2:42 are not materially contested for this proposition. The CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a manuscript-comparison technique) 3 John window does not cover these references, so the apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) is in ecm-shadow not ecm-published status.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. regulative_principle_of_worship, normative_principle_of_worship, christian_liberty_adiaphora

analogia scripturae invoked

regulative_principle_of_worship: disputed · A reading that admits in worship only what Scripture positively warrants finds explicit lexical warrant for the four articular elements (the four named items each carrying the article 'the') of Acts 2:42, for the order rule 'according to order' (kata taxin) in 1 Corinthians 14:40, and for the fixed acclamation 'our Lord, come' (marana tha) in 1 Corinthians 16:22, but finds no imperative commanding a specific liturgy or lectionary. In its strongest form this lens treats the absence of a positive command as ruling out IMPOSING set forms, while still permitting ordered worship with the named scriptural elements, so the proposition's permissibility-as-liberty (freedom-of-conscience) framing is contested rather than rejected.

normative_principle_of_worship: true · A reading that permits whatever Scripture does not forbid notes that no text prohibits set forms and positive precedent appears in 'our Lord, come' (marana tha), the model prayer introduced by 'in this way' (houtos), and the articular elements (each carrying the article 'the') of Acts 2:42. In its strongest form this lens affirms fixed liturgy as a liberty (freedom-of-conscience) matter when the gospel and Scripture's primacy are preserved, which is exactly the proposition as stated, so the lens reads the words as supporting the claim.

christian_liberty_adiaphora: true · A reading that takes Romans 14:5-6 as the governing principle for disputable practices, settled by each conscience oriented to the Lord, extends the days-and-food principle to worship form. In its strongest form this lens grants that the extension is an inference beyond the text's explicit referent, but argues that the absence of any contrary imperative for set or free worship, plus the canon's co-attestation of both, places the matter in the same liberty (freedom-of-conscience) class as the disputable practices Paul actually names.

All three lenses arrive within the same lexical underdetermination (the words alone cannot settle the question): the canon supplies set elements and free contribution and never ranks them, so the verdict turns on whether the Romans 14 liberty (freedom-of-conscience) principle lawfully extends from days and food to corporate worship form. The lexicon supports a general liberty principle and supplies precedent for set wording, but does not name liturgy as the referent of the liberty grant, so competing worship principles yield divergent conclusions.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the cited corpus commands, forbids, or leaves open the use of a formal liturgy or lectionary in corporate worship, and whether the Romans 14 liberty (freedom-of-conscience) principle extends to worship form.

The original stem preloads the liberty conclusion with the clause 'is not commanded but is a permissible Christian-liberty matter', which assumes the very adiaphora (matters indifferent, neither commanded nor forbidden) classification under test. The qualifier 'when it preserves the gospel and Scripture's primacy' is itself a substantive theological condition not directly named by the cited anchor verses. The verdict was derived on the original stem, then cross-checked against the neutralized form to confirm the lexicon independently neither licenses nor prohibits a fixed form. The lexicon leaves it open, which matches the prior verdict and the sibling prc-liturgical-vs-spontaneous-worship, hence disputed at medium confidence.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.6

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.40
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.6.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.2.42
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5010
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3779
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3134
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4342
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	1Cor.16.22
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Matt.6.9
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Acts.2.42
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.14.6

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent